PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota Land Cruiser FJ40

1960–1984 · FJ40 · BJ40

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust beats everything**
  IH8MUD veterans rank rust above every mechanical issue combined. Check door bottoms, the rear sill, the body behind the under-seat fuel tank, wheel wells, the outer front fender brace, inside sills and windscreen pillars. Get underneath and look at all of the metal.
- [ ] **Body mounts and floors**
  On 1979-and-later trucks, look hard at the body mounts. If they're heavily rusted, expect the floor pans and door pillars to be rotten too. Reproduction floor pans exist, but a badly rusted frame may not be worth saving.
- [ ] **Frame ends**
  Check the rear frame horns and the body around them, a spot IH8MUD members flag as the biggest worry on many listings.
- [ ] **Signs of hard wheeling**
  Heavily dented skid plates, gouged differential drain plugs and leaf springs with a slight S-shape all suggest a hard life. None is fatal, but they mean work ahead.
- [ ] **Driveline slop and leaks**
  Check both driveshafts for play ('any slop is too much'), look for cracks or welds on the transfer case, and watch for leaks at the transmission, transfer case, axles and wheels. Oil between engine and gearbox often means a rear main seal.
- [ ] **Compression, not the odometer**
  Mileage tells you little on a truck whose engine may have been rebuilt. A compression test does. Members put a full 2F rebuild at $2,000–3,000 in the mid-2000s, and expect $1,000–2,000 of catch-up work after purchase.
- [ ] **Brakes and fluids**
  Four-wheel drums need constant adjustment. Black brake or clutch fluid suggests the previous owner skipped bleeding, and probably other maintenance too.
- [ ] **Smog and wiring**
  In smog-check states, make sure the emissions equipment is all present and the truck passes. Messy wiring is a sign of future electrical gremlins.

YEARS TO KNOW

1976	SWEET SPOT	Front disc brakes, on top of the 2F and four-speed from 1975. IH8MUD members say most buyers prefer 1976-on trucks for those reasons, with 1978 the coveted year

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Fuel tank separator welds can crack**
  1980–1990 (NHTSA listing) · NHTSA 91V110000
- [ ] **Steering tie rod can fracture on rough roads at speed**
  1981 · NHTSA 81V117000
- [ ] **Electrical wiring campaign**
  1968–1969 · NHTSA 69V027000

- [ ] **Frame number and plate**
  Check that the frame number on the frame matches the VIN plate. On 1960s US trucks the plate is on the firewall, later on the passenger-side fender well; an A-pillar plate appears from about 3/1969, and from about 1978 the plate is pop-riveted back on the firewall. Specter Off-Road's frame-number chart dates a truck to its build month.
- [ ] **Build date vs model year**
  The driver's door pillar is stamped with the build month. A truck built late in a year is often titled as the next model year, so quote the production date at the parts counter.
- [ ] **Engine numbers**
  The firewall plate lists the engine number. A mismatch means a replacement block. Small-block Chevy V8 swaps are very common, and on BaT swapped trucks sell for less than stock ones.
- [ ] **Year tells**
  US trucks: barn doors from 1975, front discs from 1976, vent-window changes for 1977, square grille bezels and optional power steering and A/C from 1979.
- [ ] **Diesels and Bandeirantes**
  Diesel 40s (BJ, HJ) were never sold to US retail buyers, so a US diesel is an import or an ex-mine truck. Brazilian Bandeirantes (OJ and BJ codes) look like FJ40s but used Mercedes-Benz or later Toyota 14B diesels.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-cruiser/fj40/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks